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I went to ETHPrague so you don't have to (but you should)

by Twelve Meatballs | 26 June 2025 | Conference Coverage

(This is the last in a [series of articles on ETHPrague](#) commissioned through a grant from EVMavericks). You can go straight to Youtube for video playlists without unhinged commentary for both [ETHPrague 2025](#) and [Pragma Prague 2025](#).)

I arrived at Holešovice market feeling anxious. This was my first Ethereum event, and I wasn't sure what to expect. A security guard stood ramrod straight in front of an ETHPrague banner, like the hall needed protecting from unknown hordes. He glanced at my wrist dismissively and pointed at the next building.

There, things looked a bit more hopeful. A woman stood behind a make-shift counter, radiating the excitement of a first-time substitute teacher determined not to mess up.

"Hi," I said. "I'm Twelve Meatballs."

She looked at me. I looked at her.

She broke first. "I need your ticket."

Of course she did. I pulled out my phone, flustered.

"Are you—" She paused, swallowing the word *lost*. "...here for ETHPrague?"

“Yes,” I said, poking frantically at my phone.

“It’s a QR code,” she told me. She was on the verge of explaining to me what a QR code was when I finally found my ticket. She scanned it, relieved that the issue had been so easily resolved. Then, almost as an afterthought, she handed me a paper bag of goodies: plastic battery pack, postcard, and a small bottle of what looked like soy sauce. “It’s an energy drink,” she told me helpfully.

I slipped into my first session, sitting in the back like I was afraid someone was going to give me detention. “Prove you are human,” said the man on the small podium and for a moment, I wasn’t sure I could.

(I’ll link the talks as I go so you can consider which ones are worth watching.)

That was [Rémi introducing Self Protocol](#); at that point, I had no idea that I was [going to end up obsessing about their proof of humanity](#). Next, Mely.eth talked about the shift from domains to usernames and how [ENS can solve the centralization of our online identities](#).

The morning had barely started and already my brain was full.

I slipped out as unobtrusively as I could and returned to the security guard. “I’m just wondering if there’s anywhere here to get coffee.”

“I wouldn’t know,” he said. “But there’s this thing called Google Maps.”

Chastened, I turned to walk away. “Right. Thanks.”

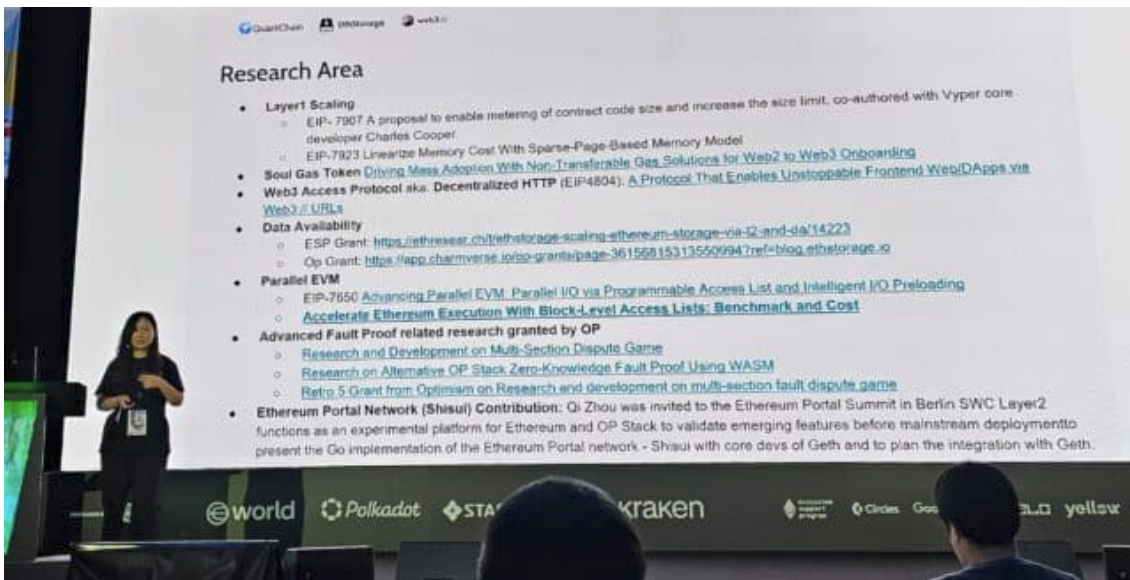
“No, wait.” He pulled out his phone. “I’m just looking.” He hadn’t been telling me off, just thinking out loud.

I smiled and glanced at his nametag. It said ShieldTech.

“OK, I found something,” said ShieldTech. Coffee was available at the opposite side of the market but he didn’t like the route Google offered. “Don’t do that. Just go straight this way and turn left. It’s called....” He struggled to translate the name. “I think Coffee King.”

I did not need the name of the coffee place and especially not in English. “Thank you very much,” I called over my shoulder, escaping back into the hall before he could be any more helpful.





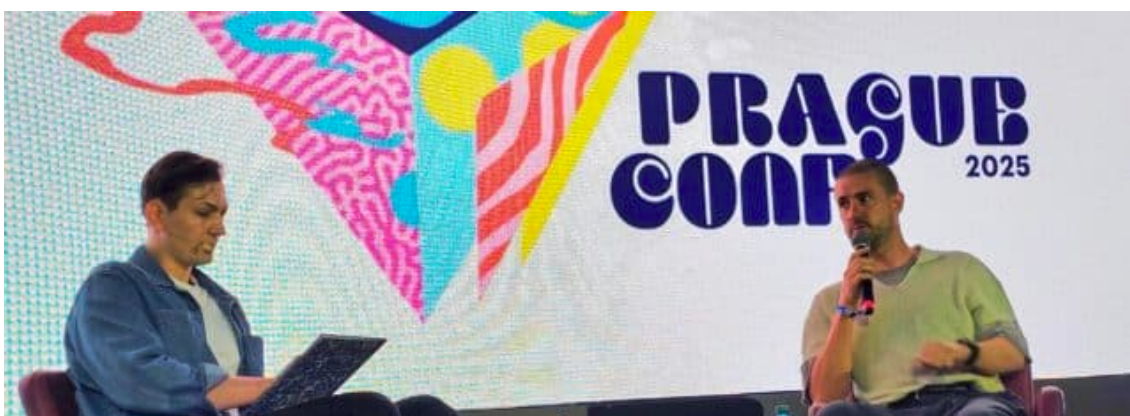
In the main presentation room, **Anthurine Xiang introduced EIP-7907** in a fantastically relatable manner, using Uber as an analogy: surely you wouldn't want your driver to pay a flat rate, regardless of the distance of your trip. But at the same time, you wanted to know how much you were likely to pay before you got in the car. I'm not saying I *understood* EIP-7907 but at least I was starting to grasp what was at stake.

Unfortunately, this seemed to mark the limit of my ability to take in new information. I wandered into **mf's talk on the new Cypherpunk generation** hoping for something revolutionary. I left mostly thinking about lunch.

I made my way to a coffee stall that may or may not have been called Coffee King. "Do you speak English?"

He rolled his eyes. "What do you want?"

I relaxed. This was much more the level of service I expected in Eastern Europe. I ordered a caffè latte, "just a single shot," I told him. I needed to pace myself for the soy sauce drink later. He rolled his eyes and handed me a milky coffee. Fortified, I returned to the conference.





The highlight of my day was [Tomasz Stańczak's fireside chat](#). Someone behind me was muttering about Layer 2s capturing all of the value and Stańczak responded as if he'd heard the man, explaining that the first focus had to be the growth of the network. "This is not the time to imagine that Ethereum has to focus on collecting fees from L2s." Instead, he suggested that we want L2s to keep winning and expanding. Our biggest challenge right now, he said, was the courage to change things and the courage to explore.

If there was an official Ethereum anthem, I would have been humming it.

Andrew Koller of Kraken's talk [on onboarding users, not just holders](#) shocked me with the stat that only 20% of users bother to withdraw funds from Kraken; the majority are holders, not users, and he wants to change this. From there, I accidentally sat in on [Gavin Wood's talk on Jam and CoreVM](#): I understood maybe 3% of it, but the parts I *did* catch were fascinating.

That was the pattern: sharp edges of clarity inside long stretches of blur. [Mariia Yaatskovska on CoW swaps solver competition](#), [DCBuilder on the trust issues of client-side proving](#) and [Tomas Studenik on what happens if we lose power](#) all had good and accessible talks.

I ended the day with [the panel on Ethereum Privacy Roadmap](#), which became [the first of my articles about the conference](#).

I have to admit that I was relieved that the content for the day was over. By the end, I didn't even have enough energy to keep saying hello to ShieldTech, who kept staring sternly ahead as if I might be a fatal distraction to his role as our protector. I found a restaurant near my hostel and collapsed into a platter of Schnitzel to consider my thoughts.





I'd worried that the conference would be too technical, aimed at devs and genius mathematicians and not relevant or even comprehensible to me. And sure, there was technical content but there was also plenty for an outsider like me to engage with. Not just plenty, too much to even keep up with.

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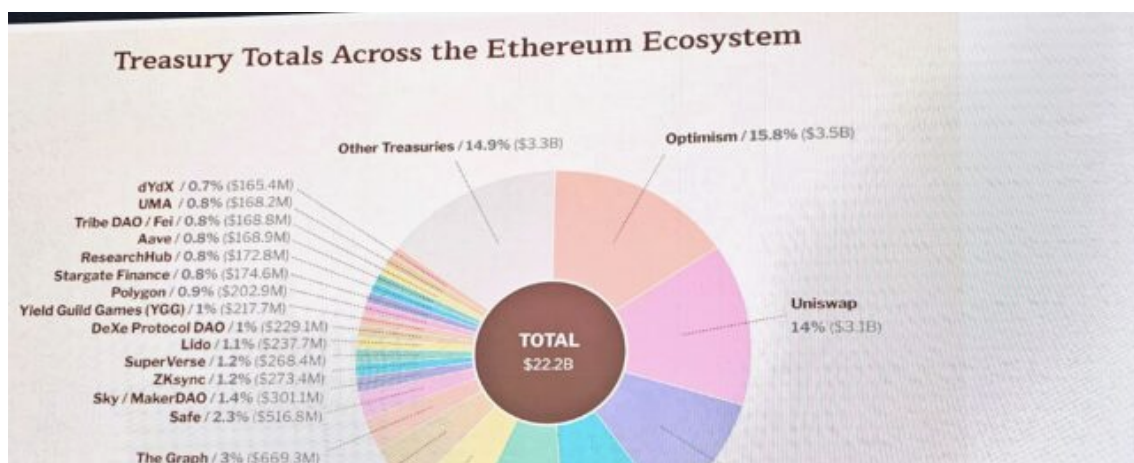
It was raining as I arrived for Day Two. ShieldTech waved me over. "I have new information," he told me. "If you want coffee, you just go into that hall there. The one marked as..." He paused, possibly counting in English in his head.

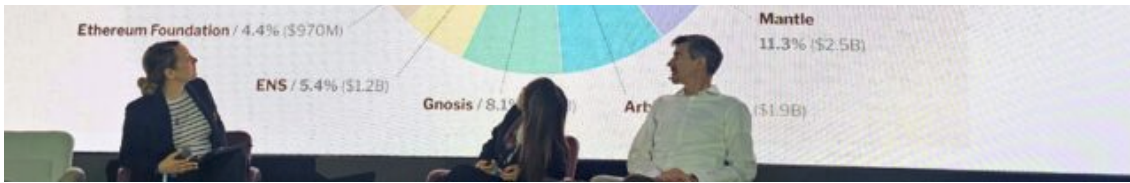
"Seventeen. That is where you should go to get coffee." I had the feeling he'd spoken more English today than in the previous three years.

"No problem," he said, and went back to watching people's wrists to make sure they had their wristbands.

I fingered my mystery soy sauce bottle and went straight to the presentation rooms.

Somehow, the day-two schedule was even better than the first. I started with [Katarzyna Kiwalska's lament](#) that companies seem to always be waiting for the right moment to start worrying about sustainability. Dr. Maurice Chiodo amused us with his consulting work on [AI projects seriously lacking in common sense](#), let alone ethics.





The first fireside talk of the day was [Aya Miyaguchi and Christopher Fabian](#) talking about the Ethereum Foundation and working with UNICEF (my favorite anecdote: Aya trying to surreptitiously text Vitalik under the table to say “I think this guy is serious” while Chris thought that maybe she was just really bored of him). This was followed by the headlining fireside chat with Vitalik Buterin and Tim Berners-Lee (ETHPrague have not released this video but you can read my take: [Dreams of Decentralization](#)).

After that line-up, I retreated to the open courtyard, where thankfully it had stopped raining. I made the mistake of checking X to see a viral post: “So is there *anyone* in crypto who’s over 30?” The online discourse seems to constantly reinforce that the crypto-verse is overwhelmingly white, male, and above all young. At ETHPrague, it couldn’t have been more off-base. Sure, two baby-faced boys of dubious hygiene sat at the table behind me, arguing about serious hackathon stuff. But at the same time, a couple in their 60s walked past, talking animatedly, dressed like they’d just stepped out of a Milan showroom. I could hear at least four languages being spoken from a range of men and women of all ages and backgrounds.

The space wasn’t *just* young and it definitely wasn’t just male. Admittedly, the two hackers definitely needed proof of being over 18 but no one questioned their right to be there. Or mine.

And honestly, that felt pretty great.

I returned to the fray with a quick smile at ShieldTech, who had gone back to pretending that he’d never seen me before.

I was ready for the next firehose of information. Sara Polak cracked us up between hard facts about [archaeology and how blockchain could make a difference](#). Paul Brody injected us with raw hopium as he talked about [enterprise use of stablecoins](#). [Joachim Schwerin from DG GROW of the European Commission](#) nailed the need for anonymity, calling out the huge systemic risks in legacy capital systems.

